

	7300GT, 6600GT, X1300XT.xls					
	NVIDIA				ATI	
Part Name	7300GT / GS	6600GT / 6600	6500	6200TC	X1300XT / X1300	X300SE
Manufacturing Process (nm)	90	110	110	110	90	110
Core Clock Speed (MHz)	450 / 550	500 / 300	350	350	450	325
(Manufacturer Reference Speeds)						
Onboard Memory (MB) / Type	256 or 128 /	256 or 128	128 or 256	16 ~ 64 /	128 ~ 512 /	64 ~ 128 /
(Manufacturer reference)	DDR2		DDR2	DDR	GDDR3/ DDR	DDR
Memory Speed (MHz)	800 / 350	1000 / 500	500	350	900 / 500	400
(Manufacturer reference speeds)						
Memory bus width (bits)	128	128	128	64	128/64	128/64
Pixel Shader units	8 / 4	8	4	4	12/4	4
Vertex Shader units	3	4	3	3	4	2

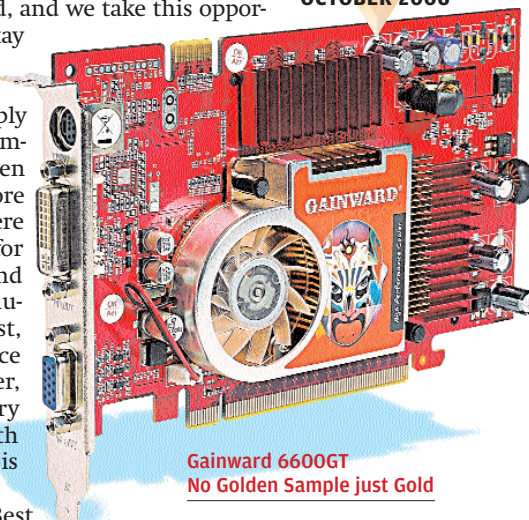
Performance

The ATI cards pretty much lagged behind the NVIDIA's by a fair margin, except for the large-hearted X1300XT from GeCube, which came close in a few tests. We do not recommend anything less than a 256 MB card, and we take this opportunity to warn you to stay away from the Turbo-cache- or Hypermemory-based cards, simply because of the performance hit you'll get when playing some of the more recent game titles. There is just no substitute for onboard memory, and any sort of sharing solution is stop-gap at best, with severe performance compromises. Moreover, this sort of main memory sharing also comes with CPU overheads, which is never a good thing.

We awarded our Best Buy Gold award to the Gainward GeForce 6600GT 256, making it a clean sweep for NVIDIA. The Best Buy Silver goes to another 6600GT based card—the 256 MB Zebtronics 6600GT, which actually beat the Gainward card in terms of performance scores, owing to a slightly higher core clock (510 MHz as opposed to the 500 MHz default).

Cards based on the NVIDIA GeForce 7300GT chipset also perform decently, but lose out to the faster (both core- and clock-wise) 6600GTs. Note that the vanilla 6600 core is a much slower card, and we do not recommend it, simply because it isn't future-proof at all; it huffs and puffs through even relatively older games. For the most frugal of us, the Palit 7300GT makes a lot

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Gainward 6600GT
No Golden Sample just Gold

of sense: it costs just Rs 4,750, has 256 MB of DDR2 memory, and performs acceptably.

Summing It All Up

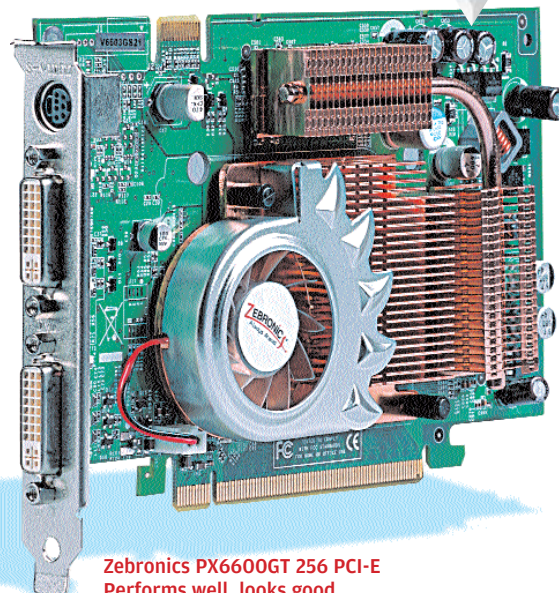
After the dust settled and temperatures dropped to normal around our test rig, we took some time to reflect on some interesting things we learnt from this test. For starters, games have evolved manifold. Whatever the genre—First Person Shooter and Real Time Strategy alike—the amount of detail and visuals that developers are building into the latest game engines is nothing short of spectacular. And virtual environments will only get prettier with upcoming game titles such as *Crysis*, *Neverwinter Nights 2*, and *Enemy Territory: Quake Wars*.

We realised that no amount of graphics processing power is ever going to be enough, and one thing's for certain—you cannot experience even half of what the developers wanted you to feel when playing with low-end cards. If you're even a little more than causally interested in gaming, make sure you set aside at least Rs 7,500 for this component alone—take our word for it: your eyes will appreciate the difference.

DirectX 10 (DX10) adds another dimension to this equation. None of these cards we've tested here are DX10 compatible, so as soon as Vista and DX10 come out, you're going to have to shell out again for a compatible card.

Going in for a super, high-end graphics card solution today is only worth it if you

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Zebtronics PX6600GT 256 PCI-E
Performs well, looks good

plan to wait till much after DX 10 cards become mainstream and affordable, before you upgrade again. Multi-GPU solutions (SLI and CrossFire) aren't recommended, simply because you'll end up wasting a lot of hard-earned cash on something that might end up being just average in less than a year! ■

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Gainward	Mediatech India	022-26361111	sales@mediatechindia.com	
Gigabyte	Gigabyte Technology (India) Ltd.	26526696 / 30616666	sales@gigabyte.in	
Leadtek	Zebtronics India Pvt. Ltd	044 - 2661 6202	zebronics@zebronics.com	
MSI	Micro Star International (MSI)	011-41758808 / 09	sanyam@msi-india.com	
XFX	Rashi Peripherals Pvt.Ltd	22- 67090810	navinderc@rptechindia.com	
Zebtronics	Zebtronics India Pvt. Ltd	044 - 2661 6202	zebronics@zebronics.com	
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